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Valerie J. Hoffman

ANNIHILATION IN THE MESSENGER OF GOD: THE DEVELOPMENT OF A SUFI PRACTICE

Scholars have long noted that the Prophet Muhammad assumed increasing importance in Sufi thought and practice over the centuries. For Sufis, belief in Muhammad's perfection often went beyond the standard affirmation of his immunity from error, and sometimes went so far as the assertions of the Spanish Arab Qadi ᶜIyad (d. 1149/50) that Muhammad had assumed all the qualities embodied in the Ninety-nine Beautiful Names of God.[1] Belief in Muhammad as a primordial cosmic light of divine origin is documented as early as the 8th to 9th centuries,[2] and reached its fullest exposition in the works of Ibn ᶜArabi (1165–1240) and his successors. Popular devotion to the Prophet in the form of poetry in his honor and celebrations of his birthday is documented at least as early as the 13th century. With the circulation of Muhammad ibn Sulayman al-Jazuli's *Dalāʾil al-khayrāt*[3] in the 15th and 16th centuries, devotion to the Prophet became a central motif of popular Islamic piety. Constance Padwick cites the 18th century as a time when Muhammad assumed increased importance in devotions as a mystical figure at the center of the spiritual universe, while prayers for a vision of the Prophet characterized 19th-century devotions.[4] Visions of the Prophet have always been part of Islamic tradition, but it has been argued that these were still relatively rare in the 15th century, though they had become a necessary attribute of those who aspired to sainthood by the late 18th and early 19th centuries.[5]

What is less clear is at what point the concept of "annihilation [of one's separate personhood] in the Messenger of God" (*fanāʾ fīʾl-rasūl*), or union with the Prophet, developed. Many scholars have considered this a distinctly "neo-Sufi" development, as evidenced particularly in the Tijaniyya, Sanusiyya, and Mirghaniyya orders, founded, respectively, by Aḥmad al-Tijani (1737–1815), Muhammad ibn ᶜAli al-Sanusi (1787–1859), and Muhammad ᶜUthman al-Mirghani (1793–1852). These scholars see the idea of spiritual union with the Prophet as a replacement for the earlier ideal of annihilation in God and describe this movement as a reform that intended to guarantee God's transcendence and move Sufism away from the teaching of Ibn ᶜArabi that God is immanent in His creation.

It is the contention of this paper that, on the contrary, the notion of union with the Prophet is found in the writing of Ibn ᶜArabi himself, and the practice of annihilation in the Messenger of God is explicitly described by a prominent commentator and

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systematizer of his thought, ᶜAbd al-Karim al-Jili (1365–1408),[6] in *Qāb qawsayn wa multaqāʾl-nāmūsayn* (A Distance of Two Bow-lengths and the Meeting Point of the Two Realms). Evidence of the profound importance of the practice of union with the Prophet is also found in the influential early-18th-century work, *Al-Ibrīz min kalām sayyidī ᶜAbd al-ᶜAzīz* (Pure Gold from the Words of my Lord ᶜAbd al-ᶜAziz [al-Dabbagh]) by Ahmad ibn al-Mubarak, which also shows marked influence from the teachings of Ibn ᶜArabi. This article will explore the theory and practice of union with the Prophet in Ibn ᶜArabi's *Al-Futūḥāt al-makkiyya* (Meccan Revelations), al-Jili's *Al-Kamālāt al-ilāhiyya fī ʾl-ṣifāt al-muḥammadiyya* (The Divine Perfections in the Muhammadan Attributes) and the aforementioned *Qāb qawsayn*, and Ibn al-Mubarak's *Al-Ibrīz*. This will be compared with 19th- and 20th-century practices in an attempt to ascertain what linkages, if any, exist between the medieval and early modern practices of union with the Prophet.

THE PERFECT MAN IN IBN ᶜARABI'S THOUGHT

Ibn ᶜArabi appears to be the first Sufi author to use the term *al-insān al-kāmil*, the "Perfect Man" or, more literally correct, the "Complete Human," who represents the fullest manifestation of the divine in the cosmos and is also the origin of all human spirits and a representation of their greatest potential.[7] This Perfect Man is identified with the spirit of Muhammad, or the eternal Muhammadan Reality, which became incarnated in the persons of the prophets, who derived their light from his and served as his "representatives" before the coming of Muhammad of Mecca. This Perfect Man also appears as the perfected saint, specifically as the *quṭb* who stands at the apex of the saintly hierarchy.

Ibn ᶜArabi interprets the hadith, "God created Adam upon His own form," to mean that, while all created things reflect some aspects of God, and taken as a whole the cosmos reflects God's attributes in their entirety, God placed all of His attributes within humanity alone. The human being is therefore a microcosm, while the cosmos may be seen as a "big human being."[8] Human beings, according to Ibn ᶜArabi, were created in the form of the Divine Name Allah, the "comprehensive" Name that contains the realities of all the other Divine Names. But only the Perfect Man actualizes all of God's Names in their fullness, becoming a clear mirror in which God can see and know Himself, and through which people can see the clearest manifestation of God. Ibn ᶜArabi refers to the process of coming to manifest the divine attributes as *takhalluq*, which William Chittick translates as "assuming the traits."[9] The Qurʾan's commendation to Muhammad (68:4) that he has a "mighty morality" (to use A. J. Arberry's translation of *khuluq ᶜaẓīm*) is a reference to the perfection of Muhammad's realization of "his divine potentialities through his actualization of the divine names." For this reason, while humanity in general forms the *barzakh*—boundary or point of mediation—between the spiritual and corporeal worlds, the Perfect Man is the Supreme Barzakh (*al-barzakh al-aᶜlā*).

The supremacy of Muhammad among the prophets and Perfect Men is demonstrated, according to Ibn ᶜArabi, by the hadith in which Muhammad says he was given the "all-comprehensive words" (*jawāmiᶜ al-kalim*). These words, says Ibn ᶜArabi, are God's Names and indicate the all-inclusiveness of Muhammad's prophetic message

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and why he will be the master of humanity of the Day of Resurrection.[10] Not only does this indicate that the religion taught by Muhammad comprises all other revealed religions, and that he is the most perfect of all perfect men, but it has direct implications for the spiritual aspirations and methods of the Sufi.

According to Ibn ᶜArabi, only the Perfect Man worships in true witness of God. Other human beings are veiled by their persons from seeing God, but true to the proverb, "A person is his brother's mirror," one may see in others what one cannot see in oneself. Muhammad alone had a universal mission because of the perfect balance and inclusiveness of his constitution, so a full disclosure of God may be seen only in him. Ibn ᶜArabi writes:

> Know that you do not have [this perfection] and you do not have this constitution which belongs to Muhammad, peace and blessings be upon him, and that no matter how much the Real discloses Himself to you in the mirror of your heart, your heart will only show you what is according to its own constitution and the form of its shape. You know how far you are below the rank achieved by Muhammad in the knowledge of his Lord in his formation. So cling to faith and follow him! Place him before you like the mirror in which you see your form and the form of others. If you do this, you will know that God must disclose Himself to Muhammad in his mirror. I have already told you that the mirror has an effect on the viewpoint of the one who looks into it. So the manifestation of the Real in the mirror of Muhammad is the most perfect, most balanced, and most beautiful manifestation, because of his mirror's particular qualities. When you perceive Him in the mirror of Muhammad, you will have perceived from Him a perfection that you could not perceive by looking at your own mirror.[11]

Muhammad's comprehensive realization of all the divine names makes him the perfect link between God and humanity. Ibn ᶜArabi's encouragement to his reader to "place him before you like the mirror in which you see your form" may imply the kind of visualization practices that are associated with *fanāᵓ fīᵓl-rasūl*. Ibn ᶜArabi, like many other Sufis, takes comfort in the assurance given by Muhammad in hadith that Satan cannot assume his form, so whoever sees him in a vision sees him in truth. Ibn ᶜArabi points out that this contrasts with visions of God Himself, because God is manifest in the forms of all things, though usually in a limited and incomplete manner.[12]

In another passage, Ibn ᶜArabi mentions another Sufi practice that can induce the Prophet to appear to the devotee: total immersion in blessing the Prophet (*al-ṣalāt ᶜalā ᵓl-nabī*):

> He [the devotee] confines himself to this *dhikr*[13] and is patient until he appears to him. I never met anyone at this rank except an old blacksmith in Ishbiliyya who was known as "God, bless Muhammad" (*Allāhumma, ṣallī ᶜalā Muḥammad*). He was not known by any other name. . . . He doesn't talk to anyone except out of necessity. If anyone comes asking him to make something for him from iron, he asks as pay only that the customer bless Muhammad. No man, boy, or woman came to him without blessing Muhammad until he left. . . . Whatever is revealed to the one who does this *dhikr* is true and immune from error, for nothing comes to him except through the Messenger.[14]

He cites the story of a man in the days of Abu Yazid al-Bistami (d. 874) who felt no need to visit the great saint because of the sufficiency of his vision of God. But when he finally saw Abu Yazid, he died on the spot. Abu Yazid commented, "He used to see God according to his own capacity, so when he saw us the Real disclosed Himself

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to him according to our capacity, and he could not bear it, so he died." Ibn ʿArabi concludes, "Since the matter is thus, we know that our vision of the Real in the Muhammadan form by the Muhammadan vision is the most perfect vision [of God] that there is. So we do not cease to encourage people to [seek] this."[15]

Muhammad's role as intercessor for the Muslims and sole accessor to the presence of God are logical corollaries, from Ibn ʿArabi's point of view, of his unique cosmic status as the Supreme Barzakh. His intercessory role exists from the beginning of creation, for all creatures receive their measure of light from him. Therefore, although Ibn ʿArabi does not use the terms *fanāʾ fīʾl-rasūl*, or "union," with him, he provides a theoretical perspective that could lead directly to the development of the practices of visualization and concentration that characterize these goals. Indeed, the practical implications for mystical practice are brought out fully in the work of a writer who closely followed his thought and commented on his writings: ʿAbd al-Karim al-Jili.

MUHAMMAD AS BARZAKH IN THE WRITINGS OF AL-JILI

The work in which al-Jili describes the practice of annihilation in the Messenger is entitled *Qāb qawsayn wa multaqā ʾl-nāmūsayn* (A Distance of Two Bow-lengths and the Meeting Point of the Two Realms). The title refers to the Qurʾanic verse that describes Muhammad's encounter with a glorious being who "was on the highest horizon, then came closer and hovered, coming within two bows' length or closer. Then he revealed to his servant what he revealed" (53:7–10). *Qāb qawsayn* is part ten of an allegedly forty-part work entitled *Al-Nāmūs al-aʿẓam wa ʾl-qāmūs al-aqdam fī maʿrifat qadr al-nabī ṣallā ʾllāhu ʿalayhi wa sallam* (The Greatest Realm and the Oldest Ocean in the Knowledge of the Stature of the Prophet, May God Bless Him and Grant Him Peace). Only parts nine through twelve of this work have been found.[16]

Al-Jili's theological justification for the centrality of the Prophet's position in the life of the believer is expounded in some detail in an earlier work, to which he refers in *Qāb qawsayn*: *Al-Kamālāt al-ilāhiyya fīʾl-ṣifāt al-muḥammadiyya* (The Divine Perfections in the Muhammadan Attributes).[17] In this work, obviously building on such passages as those previously quoted from Ibn ʿArabi's *Futūḥāt*, al-Jili emphasizes Muhammad's fitness to be called by all of the Divine Names by virtue of his creation from the light of God's Essence, whereas all other things were created from the light of God's attributes. God made Muhammad the most perfect replica (*nuskha*) of non-existence and existence. According to a saying frequently cited in Sufi sources, God was a "hidden treasure" who desired to be known, so he made the creation so they could know Him in Him.[18] However, writes al-Jili,

> The existent things in that eternal manifestation existed in His knowledge as immutable entities (*aʿyān thābita*) which He knew from their innate capacities (*qawābil*) that they would not be able to know Him, because of the lack of correspondence (*nisba*) between origination and eternity, and love is required for His manifestation to them so they could know Him. So he created from that love a Beloved (*ḥabīb*) set apart for the theophanies of His Essence, and He created the world from that Beloved, in order to form a correspondence between Himself and His creation, so they could know Him by virtue of that correspondence. So the world is the manifestation of the theophanies of the attributes, and the Beloved, God's blessings and peace be on him, is the manifestation of the theophanies of the essence.

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Just as the attributes are derived from the Essence, likewise the world is derived from the Beloved. He is the intermediary (*wāsiṭa*) between God and the world, and the proof of this are his words, "I am from God and the believers are from me."[20]

The Qurʾan says that Muhammad was sent as a mercy to all creatures (21:107). Al-Jili says this is not only in the specific sense of his mission on Earth, but also in a general sense because God's mercy on all things is mediated through the Muhammadan Reality. It is through the Muhammadan Reality that all things have their capacity to receive the divine effusion and existence, each according to its measure.

The Muhammadan Reality, says al-Jili, is like the flow of life in all living things. It is by virtue of this fact that it is appropriate to call Muhammad by the Divine Name *al-Raḥmān*, the Merciful. Muhammad's connection to each of the Ninety-nine Beautiful Names of God is spelled out in detail. Muhammad's perfection pervades every aspect of his being, even his body, which is the most beautiful and perfect of bodies, so pure that even his excretions were non-polluting. Al-Jili supports these ideas with frequent citations from Qadi ʿIyad's *Kitāb al-shifāʾ bi-taʿrīf ḥuqūq al-muṣṭafā* (Book of Healing by Acquainting [the Reader with] the Rights of the Chosen One), which exerted a great deal of influence on popular veneration of the Prophet.

Because Adam was created as a replica (*nuskha*) of Muhammad, every human being has the innate capacity (*qābiliyya*) to attain divine perfection, but not everyone is prepared for that. Capacity and readiness (*istiʿdād*) may be contrasted through analogy with a king who chooses only one woman as his consort from among many. Any woman has the natural disposition or capacity (*qābiliyya*) to be his consort, but only the one who has prepared herself by adorning herself with jewelry will be chosen. "So adorn yourself, brother, so the king will choose you for himself!" exhorts al-Jili. This is done, he says, "by stripping yourself of everything but Him, on the outside and the inside, and emptying yourself for Him, in witness and awareness, while fulfilling all the religious laws. Your meeting Him is His presentation to you of His Names, then His Attributes, then His Essence, until He appears to you from you in you, because He is your very being (*ʿayn*)."[21]

It is up to each individual seeker to come to realize that he (the seeker) is the Greatest Name of God. If he can perceive the divine perfections in himself, the doors of divine vision will be opened to him, transcending the boundaries of humanity. Muhammad is the *barzakh*, or boundary line, linking divinity and creation, according to *Qāb qawsayn*, but in *al-Kamālāt al-ilāhiyya*, al-Jili also tells his reader, "You are a *barzakh* between the sea of divinity and the sea of creation and form." Adam's creation in the form of Muhammad, and Muhammad's creation from the Divine Essence, allow every human being, according to his preparedness, to partake of that same divinity. The result, says al-Jili, is immersion and completion, and the elimination of all duality, although the appearance of duality may at times yet remain.[22] This is the ultimate goal of all of al-Jili's voluminous writings on the nature of the cosmos.

ANNIHILATION IN THE MESSENGER: PRACTICAL DIMENSIONS

In *Qāb qawsayn*, al-Jili repeats, in briefer form, some of what he wrote in *al-Kamālāt al-ilāhiyya*, but he stresses the practical dimensions of Muhammad's intermediary

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role in the spiritual realizations of the individual Sufi. Reception of divine effusion (*fayḍ*) corresponds to the capacity (*qābiliyya*) of the receiver, not just the giver, just as your reflection will appear long in a long mirror, wide in a wide one, and well proportioned in a good mirror.[23] There is only one way to God, al-Jili warns his readers, and that is through Muhammad. All a saint does is seek the rain that falls from the clouds of his virtue and facilitates its billows.

Anyone who thinks that he is ascending without his mediation will find that his ascent is a fall into his own prison and scum (*sijnihi wa ḥuththālatihi*). You must attach yourself to his exalted presence, and cling to "the firmest handle" (*al-ʿurwa ʾl-wuthqā*)[24] from his unapproachable rank, all the while calling forth this perfect image which contains all of the meanings and forms of existence. Do this until the secrets flow onto your spirit, and your spirit onto your heart, and your heart onto your soul, and your soul onto your body, from his love, a spiritual drink that refreshes both spirit and form, extinguishing all traces of yourself. You go with the Messenger of God in you as a substitute for you. Then you can obtain the capacity of his exalted Reality in your being to know what no other creature has known of the One you worship. Because God the Exalted has set apart Muhammad, God's blessings and peace be upon him, for the greatest and most perfect divine manifestations which no other capacity can accept in this world or the next. If the earth of your existence is illuminated with the light of his sun, and the olefactory sense of your spirit is perfumed with the fragrance of these radiant gardens, your body will become balanced with its proportion of his mold and capacity to receive some of these divine manifestations, and you will come to be "looking at their Lord."[25]

Muhammad's exalted status, al-Jili makes clear, has practical applications for the believer, who cannot enter God's presence without first undertaking specific disciplines enabling the seeker to unite with Muhammad in such a manner that all traces of the seeker's self are extinguished and he conforms to the Muhammadan mold. Much of the text of *Qāb qawsayn* is devoted to describing the superlative perfection of Muhammad, spiritually, morally, and physically. After a detailed description of his physique, manners, and daily habits, al-Jili writes:

I have only described for you his physical form to enable you to picture it in your mind [lit., "between your eyes"], so you can observe it in every hour, until its image takes shape for you. Then you will have reached the rank of those who witness him, may God bless him and grant him peace. Then you will achieve the supreme happiness and join the Companions, may God be pleased with them all. If you cannot do this constantly, then at least summon this noble image in all its perfection while you are blessing him, may God bless him and grant him peace.[26]

Here al-Jili provides a rationale for the minute attention Muslim writers have given not only to the Prophet's behavior, which is a model for all Muslims, but to his physical appearance. The descriptions of his appearance aid the Sufi adept in visualizing the Prophet, until this becomes a true vision and spiritual realization is opened to the disciple.

The station of love, according to al-Jili, is the highest station of perfection. God, the hidden treasure who desired to be known, manifested His divine realities through the medium of love, through the medium of the Muhammadan spirit. Were it not for the Muhammadan Reality, the creation would not have come into existence. As God told Muhammad in the Night of the Ascension, "Were it not for you,

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I would not have created the spheres." So Muhammad was the originally intended object of divine love; he alone is the Beloved. His community is loved only because its members follow him, as it says in the Qurʾan: "Say: If you love God, follow me, and God will love you" (3:31). This follows from the fact that they were created from him.[27]

Al-Jili writes that there are nine levels of human love. At the seventh stage, *shaghaf*, the lover passes away from himself (*yafnā ʿan nafsihi*). If the lover passes away from both himself and his annihilation, he has reached the eighth stage, *ghurām*. At the ninth level, *ʿishq*, absolute love, the lover passes away from consciousness of both himself and his lover, so that "the whole affair becomes one thing. Each one takes on the form of the other. The lover's spirit takes on the form of the loved one, and attaches itself to that spiritual image in such a way as to merge (*al-tamāzuj*) with it, as vitriol attaches to bile, so that it is impossible to separate them."[28] This is the type of love the true seeker of God should have with the Prophet.

The Qurʾan says that Muhammad is more deserving of the believers than they themselves (33:6), and in a hadith Muhammad says that a person does not have faith until he loves Muhammad more than himself, his money, and his children. If you do not have this love, al-Jili counsels his readers, you must ask God's forgiveness and constantly remember the Prophet, demonstrating proper etiquette with him, doing what he commands, and avoiding what he prohibits. If you do this, perhaps you will be gathered with him into Paradise on the Day of Judgment, for he has said, "A man will be with the one he has loved." Such love may be demonstrated by honoring the Prophet and his Companions and the People of his House, and observing etiquette with all people of God. But there is a second kind of love, which is spiritual attachment. This, too, is of two types. Concerning the first, al-Jili writes:

> Continuously call to mind his image, observing etiquette with him. If you have seen him in your sleep, call that image to mind. If you have not, bless him, and in your *dhikr* imagine yourself with him in his life. He hears you and sees you whenever you mention him, for he is described by the attributes of God, and God sits with those who remember Him. If you cannot do this and you have visited his tomb, recall its image in your mind. Whenever you do *dhikr* or bless him, be as if you were standing at his tomb, in all honor and respect, until his spiritual substance appears to you. If you have not visited his tomb, continue to bless him, and imagine him hearing you, and be entirely respectful, so your blessings will reach him.[28]

In this passage al-Jili combines the practice of blessing the Prophet, endorsed by Ibn ʿArabi, with visualizing and imagining the Prophet, in order to draw the disciple into his presence.

The second type of "spiritual attachment" involves "summoning his perfect Reality, described by the characteristics of perfection, combining both splendor and beauty. . . . You will never be able to summon all that pertains to him until you know that he, may God's blessing and peace be upon him, is the perfect dividing line (*barzakh*) standing between the two sides of the realities of existence, the eternal and the originated, for he is the reality of each of the two sides, in essence and in attributes, because he is created from the light of the Essence, and the Essence contains all of its qualities, acts, and effects."

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He offers his readers an image to explain the meaning of the verse, "He drew near and suspended, and was two bow-lengths away or closer" (53:9), and in doing so also reveals the meaning of his title for this short work, "The Distance of Two Bow-lengths and the Meeting Point of the Two Realms." All of Reality may be conceived as a single circle divided in two, between the true, necessary, eternal existence and the created, possible, originated existence. Each half of the circle is a bow's length. The line dividing them is the string of the bow, used by each bow. The division of this line is "the distance of two bow-lengths." "The Muhammadan station combines the divine perfections and the perfections of creation in form and meaning. He is the barrier between the divine and created realities because he is the reality of all realities. Therefore his station on the Night of his Ascension was above the Throne, and you know that the Throne is the upper limit of created things. So all created things were beneath him, and his Lord was above him."[29]

In a passage reminiscent of the aforementioned anecdote regarding Abu Yazid al-Bistami, al-Jili says that when the perfect saint increases in his love for God, he experiences tranquillity and constancy in his remembrance of Him, whereas the more he knows the Prophet, he evinces signs of turbulence in his remembrance of him. This is because the saint's knowledge of God is according to the measure of the saint's capacity and limitations, whereas his knowledge of the Prophet is according to the capacity of the Prophet, in which the saint is unable to be firm. He shows signs of agitation, because it is beyond his limits. Al-Jili writes, "The more the saint increases his knowledge of the Prophet, the more perfect he is than others, and the more established in the divine presence, and the more profoundly he enters into the knowledge of God."[30]

At the end of *Qāb qawsayn*, al-Jili speaks of how a saint who is in this relationship with the Prophet can serve as a link for another seeker, virtually bestowing upon him a mystical experience and station that would otherwise be unattainable. He writes:

> One of the characteristics of the Prophet is that whenever any saint sees him in one of the divine manifestations wearing one of the robes of perfection, he [the Prophet] grants that robe to the one who has this vision, and it then belongs to him. If he is strong, he can wear it immediately. If not, it is stored away for him with God for him to wear when he has attained sufficient strength and preparedness, either in this world or the next. When he obtains that robe and wears it in this world or in the next, it is a gift to him from the Prophet, may God bless him and grant him peace. This is *futuwwa*.[31]
>
> If anyone sees that saint in a divine manifestation wearing that prophetic robe, the saint removes it and grants it to him as a gift from the Prophet for the second visionary, while the first saint receives from the Muhammadan station a more perfect robe in its place. This goes on indefinitely.[32]

This channeling of grace and direct spiritual attainment through the saint appears to presage the later development of the doctrine of annihilation in the shaykh.[33]

It is unclear whether this particular text by al-Jili received sufficient dissemination to have made a direct impact on the promotion of the practice of meditation on the Prophet in order to achieve annihilation in him. What is clear is that this practice was known and taught well before the 18th century, and that it appears to be a natural development from the teachings of Ibn ᶜArabi. The image used by al-Jili, de-

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picting reality as a circle divided in two in which the dividing line, or *barzakh*, is the Muhammadan Reality, appears in a 14th-century Persian text written by Muhammad Shirin Maghribi (d. 1385), a lesser-known follower of the doctrines of Ibn ᶜArabi whose thought provides the basis for the cosmology and practice of the Shattariyya, a Sufi order of Mughal India.[34] This manner of depicting the cosmos and the linkage of the Muhammadan Reality with both originated and eternal existence is likely to have existed before al-Jili. What we do not know is whether the practices of visualization and meditation on the Prophet that al-Jili bases on this doctrine were frequently practiced in al-Jili's time. The lack of explicit delineation of these practices in other texts does not necessarily indicate that they were unknown, for al-Jili's works have a particular focus (uncharacteristic of many writers in the school of Ibn ᶜArabi) of drawing a link between mystical theory and practical implications.[35] Later Sufi development of the concept of annihilation in the shaykh is also based on seeing the shaykh as "mirror of the Prophet" and "mirror of God," the *barzakh* between the upper and lower worlds.[36]

UNION WITH THE PROPHET IN THE TEACHINGS OF ᶜABD AL-ᶜAZIZ AL-DABBAGH

Lacunae in the current state of scholarship on late medieval Sufism make it impossible to provide a complete account of the further development of devotion to the Prophet as a central aspect of Sufi practice. However, some information on this period may be gleaned from *Al-Ibrīz fī kalām Sayyidī ᶜAbd al-ᶜAzīz*, a work of considerable importance that has received scant attention from scholars.[37] It may be found in Sufi libraries throughout the Arab world.[38] Written around the year 1717 by Ahmad ibn al-Mubarak (d. 1742), the book records the life and teachings of his shaykh, ᶜAbd al-ᶜAziz al-Dabbagh, who lived in Fez from 1679–1719/20. The influence of Ibn ᶜArabi is evident throughout the book, but its teachings on the Prophet Muhammad are also strikingly similar to those commonly associated with "neo-Sufism."

Al-Dabbagh tells us that for eleven years he went from shaykh to shaykh in a vain search for mystical revelation. He used to visit the tomb of Sidi ᶜAli ibn Harazham every Thursday evening. There, along with others who spent the night in the shrine, he would recite *al-Burda*, a poem by al-Busiri (1211–94) written in honor of the Prophet. One night as he was leaving the shrine, he encountered a man who told him things about himself (i.e., al-Dabbagh) that he could not have known if he were not a saint. Al-Dabbagh asked him to teach him a *wird* and *dhikr*.[39] At first the stranger ignored the request, but after much insistence, the man (later revealed to him as al-Khidr) agreed, provided al-Dabbagh swore by God that he would faithfully recite the prayer he taught him and never leave it. He told him to pray 7,000 times a day, "Lord God, by the stature of our lord Muhammad ibn ᶜAbd Allah, God's blessings and peace be on him, unite (*ijmaᶜ*) me with our lord Muhammad ibn ᶜAbd Allah in this world before the next." Al-Dabbagh did as he was told and was guided to a shaykh. He describes how he inherited the spiritual "secrets," or essence, of his shaykh after his death, and shortly thereafter experienced *faṭh*—"opening" or revelation—an extraordinary experience in which he felt himself expanding until he was able to perceive the entire cosmos and all that was in it. The following day, he encountered a

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man from Borno,[40] ᶜAbd Allah al-Barnawi, who had been sent by God to guide him, and three days afterward he had his first waking vision of the Prophet. At this, al-Barnawi rejoiced, saying, "Before today I worried about you, but today, since God has united you with His mercy [the Prophet], the lord of existence, my heart is secure and my mind is at ease." He prayed for him and returned to his own country.[41]

At several points throughout the book, al-Dabbagh emphasizes the importance of seeing the Prophet for any disciple who wishes to attain true knowledge of God. He says:

> If he attains the witness (*mushāhada*) of the Prophet while awake he is secure from Satan's deceit, because he is united with (*li ᵓjtimāᶜihi maᶜa*) the mercy of God, which is our lord and prophet and master, Muhammad. Then his meeting with the noble body (*al-dhāt al-sharīf*)[42] is the cause of his knowledge of the Real and his witness of His eternal essence, because he finds that the noble body is absent in the Real, enraptured in witnessing Him. The saint, by the blessing of the noble body, remains attached to the Real and increases in his knowledge of Him little by little until he attains witness and the secrets of mystical knowledge and the lights of love. This is the second *fatḥ*, and it divides the people of truth from the people of vanity. As for the first *fatḥ*, that is like what happens to the people of darkness who witness ephemeral things and gain mastery over them. You will see a person engaged in such vanities walking on water or flying through the sky or bringing food from an unknown source, though he doesn't even believe in God."[43]

Al-Dabbagh seems painfully aware of the possibility that miracles commonly attributed to saints may come from a source other than God, and describes the vision of the Prophet while awake as the distinguishing characteristic of true saints. It is also clear from this passage that the vision of the Prophet is not an end unto itself but a necessary step in the process of mystical revelation and leads the adept directly into the divine presence.

Al-Dabbagh also acknowledges that although Satan cannot impersonate Muhammad, not all visions of the Prophet are equally real. Just as Ibn ᶜArabi and al-Jili had attributed differences in people's perceptions of God to differences in their "mirrors" or innate capacities, so does al-Dabbagh in relation to visions of the Prophet. Al-Dabbagh categorizes many things according to a gradation of light and darkness, and this applies even to visions of the Prophet. Few people see the actual physical body (*ᶜayn al-dhāt*) of the Prophet, but many see his form (*ṣūra*). This form may be seen in a dream or while awake. This is possible because his form is a light that pervades the whole world and can therefore be seen by many people at the same time, just as one can see one's face in the mirror. But the light is according to the mirror. If, for example, a person sees the Prophet in a dream encouraging him to pursue a worldly end, this is an indication of the darkness (worldliness) of the visionary. The one who has received *fatḥ* will follow the form of the Prophet with his inner vision (*baṣīra*) and break through by its light to the place of the noble body. Someone who has not received mystical illumination may also be granted the actual presence of the true body of the Prophet if the latter decides to come to him as a reward for his perfect love and sincerity. "He [Muhammad] appears in other forms, which are the forms of the prophets and messengers, and the forms of the saints of his community [the Muslims] from his time until the Day of Resurrection. . . . Many disciples see him in the bodies of their shaykhs. . . . It is not obtained all at once, but comes by degrees, little

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by little."[44] It is intriguing to ponder whether the possibility of identification of the Prophet with one's shaykh could be linked to the development of meditating on the form of one's shaykh as a means of attaining union with the Prophet, and ultimately to attain the presence of God. Nonetheless, al-Dabbagh emphasizes that mystical revelation and visions of the Prophet come about not by human effort but by the act of God. Otherwise, they would cease when a person is heedless. Even the strongest person is incapable of producing such experiences for himself. Those who are blessed with witnessing the noble body are privileged with immeasurable pleasure (*lidhdha*). It is even better than entering paradise, he says, because in paradise everyone will experience only a particular enjoyment (*naʿīm*), but in the presence of the Prophet one experiences all the pleasures of paradise.[45]

UNION WITH THE PROPHET IN THE "NEO-SUFI" ORDERS

For some time, Western scholars have seen the Sufi orders that formed in the late 18th and early 19th centuries as distinct from traditional Sufism in a number of ways. In contrast to the largely introspective and metaphysical orientation of medieval Sufism, these orders adopted activist moral, social, and political postures that have led some observers to see them as somewhat analogous to the anti-Sufi Wahhabi movement, which emerged in Arabia in the 18th century. A number of the orders described in this manner emerged in North Africa, specifically the Tijaniyya, followers of Ahmad al-Tijani, and the Sanusiyya and Mirghaniyya, both of which were founded on the teachings of Ahmad ibn Idris (d. 1837). These orders, though undeniably Sufi, have been seen as different enough from traditional Sufism to warrant the name "neo-Sufi." The reformist and proselytizing direction of the social role of these orders leads them to stand out from earlier orders, and may warrant use of a term such as "neo-Sufism." What is less certain is the extent to which these orders rejected the metaphysical teachings and spiritual methods of medieval Sufism, as alleged by Fazlur Rahman, who seems to have originated the term "neo-Sufism." Rahman defined neo-Sufism as a movement in which Sufism "was reformed on orthodox lines and interpreted in an activist sense. . . . Sufism was largely stripped of its ecstatic and metaphysical character and content which were replaced by a content which was nothing else than the postulates of the orthodox religion." Rahman further said that the school of Ibn Idris "rejected the idea of a union with God and postulated instead a union with the spirit of the prophet Muhammad as the only possible and legitimate goal for the Sufi."[46] A similar assertion had been made earlier by Sir Hamilton Gibb,[47] and is echoed in works by J. Spencer Trimingham[48] and John Voll.[49] Jonathan Katz has seen neo-Sufism as a process of "democratization of sanctity."[50]

One aspect of neo-Sufi teaching that has attracted particular attention is the emphasis these orders place on visions of the Prophet. The Sanusiyya and Mirghaniyya encouraged their disciples to meditate on the Prophet through visualization in order to attain union with him. This has been interpreted by Gibb, Trimingham, and Rahman as a substitution of mystical union with the Prophet (an apparent reference to *fanāʾ fī ʾl-rasūl*, although Rahman interprets it in a moral rather than a mystical sense) for mystical union with God. Trimingham sees a commonality between the teachings of Ahmad ibn Idris and his contemporary Ahmad al-Tijani (d. 1815), and

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describes them as having initiated the "Muhammadan Path" which stresses meditation on the Prophet in the hope of achieving *fanāʾ* in him. In his opinion, this changed the entire basis of Sufi devotional life. However, we have seen that in the school of Ibn ʿArabi, *fanā fī 'l-rasūl* was not a substitute for annihilation in God but a means to it. Did the Tijani and Idrisi orders really substitute the one for the other? Is union with God no longer considered possible? Or do the teachings of these orders actually reflect a deep continuity with the medieval tradition of *fanāʾ fī 'l-rasūl*? This is what will be explored in this section.

Pertinent to this question is the attitude of the new orders toward the teachings of Ibn ʿArabi and the possibility of the influence of Ibn ʿArabi's ideas on their teachings and practices. R. S. O'Fahey and Bernd Radtke have summarized the scholarly consensus concerning neo-Sufism in an article that disputes the utility of the term. Among the perceived doctrinal characteristics of neo-Sufi orders that have bearing on our study are the rejection of Ibn ʿArabi's teachings, especially his doctrine of *waḥdat al-wujūd* (the unity of being); rejection of the master-disciple relationship and the hierarchical mystical Way leading to illumination, with an emphasis instead on moral and social teaching; and "union" with the spirit of the Prophet and a general emphasis on the "Muhammadan Way."[51] However, a number of scholars who have analyzed the teachings of Ahmad ibn Idris and Ahmad al-Tijani have recognized the deep influence of Ibn ʿArabi.

Concerning Ahmad al-Tijani, Jamil Abun-Nasr explicitly states that the marked influence of Ibn ʿArabi's thought on al-Tijani led the latter's followers to study Ibn ʿArabi's writings. Al-Tijani claimed to be both *quṭb al-aqṭāb* (the Supreme Pole, possessing the highest rank in the saintly hierarchy) and *khatm al-wilāya* (the Seal of Sainthood). Al-Tijani claimed to have received all the spiritual emanations from the Muhammadan Reality that had been received by the pre-Muhammadan prophets, acting as deputy of the Muhammadan Reality and serving as the Supreme Barzakh (*barzakh al-barāzikh*) in the world. Ahmad al-Tijani claimed to have received his teachings and the special prayers or litanies of the order (*awrād*) directly from the Prophet in visions he received while awake. It is because al-Tijani recognized only the Prophet as his master that the Tijaniyya call their order the Muhammadan Path. But access to the Prophet remained the exclusive privilege of the order's founder; for other Tijanis, access to knowledge was only through their master, who did not allow them to associate with other orders. The Tijanis did not pursue ascetic practices, and they boasted that their *awrād* were more effective than those of the Qadiriyya because they only had to recite them six hundred times a day, whereas the Qadiris needed to recite theirs 3,000 times a day.[52]

O'Fahey analyzed letters written by Ahmad ibn Idris and concluded that Ibn Idris was also very much influenced by the writings of Ibn ʿArabi, taught Ibn ʿArabi's *Fuṣūṣ al-ḥikam* (Bezels of Wisdom) to his inner circle of disciples, and appeared to endorse the latter's notion of *waḥdat al-wujūd*.[53] O'Fahey describes Ibn Idris's endorsement of Ibn ʿArabi as more "qualified"[54] in his debates with the Wahhabis, but this probably reflects common Sufi prudence regarding public endorsement of Ibn ʿArabi, whose reputation among non-Sufis for extremist interpretations stands undiminished to this day, but whose influence on Sufi thought likewise persists.[55] The

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more recent article on neo-Sufism co-authored by O'Fahey and Radtke issues a much clearer statement of the direct appropriation of Ibn ᶜArabi's thought in the teachings of Ibn Idris and his disciples.[56] O'Fahey's study demonstrates that Ibn Idris's thought and practice lie very much in the mainstream of Sufi mystical tradition, with particularly close links to the Shadhiliyya. In contrast to Ahmad al-Tijani, Ibn Idris advocated meditation on the Prophet and the possibility of union with him as a goal for all members of the order. Whether Ibn Idris taught the doctrine of annihilation in the shaykh is unclear, although the manner in which he describes his close relationship with al-Sanusi suggests that this is possible.[57]

Ahmad al-Sharif describes the path of the Sanusiyya, which was founded by Ibn Idris's deputy (*khalīfa*) and closest disciple, as "following the Sunna in words, deeds and spiritual states, and constant preoccupation with blessing the Prophet." This involved reading the hadith collection of al-Bukhari, Malik ibn Anas's *al-Muwaṭṭaᵓ*, and other legal and mystical works, in addition to the repetition of prayers and visualization.[58] Evans-Pritchard writes that the chief aim of the Sanusiyya is "to make a man a good Muslim rather than a good mystic." He discusses Sanusi practices of meditating on the Prophet:

> It is for this reason that, as Sayyid Ahmad [grandson of the order's founder] insists, perfection is to be sought through spiritual identification with the Prophet Muhammad rather than with God, at any rate for ordinary people. This is to be attained by contemplation of the essence of the Prophet and by an inner knowledge of him through constant imitation of his actions, attention to his words, and blessing him. The contemplation should be so intense that veneration of the Prophet pervades the adept till at last he hears only his name and has only his form before the eyes of the intellect. Then the Prophet becomes his sole guide and counsellor.[59]

Evans-Pritchard's qualification that union with God is excluded as a goal for the common run of disciples allows for the possibility that for some union with God remained a possibility. Our previous discussion of the teachings of al-Dabbagh indicates that union with the Prophet need not exclude an aspiration to the presence of God; indeed, it necessarily leads the Sufi into God's presence. Likewise, C. C. Adams speaks of those in the Sanusiyya who had "progressed so far along the mystic path they have divested themselves of all will and desire and reached the stage of satisfaction with their present attainments of the mystic experience of God."[60] Significantly, O'Fahey says of Ahmad ibn Idris's teachings that meditation on the Prophet appears not as a substitute for the final goal of union with God—for annihilation in the Prophet is seen as a means to annihilation in God, not a substitute for it—but as a denial of a major intercessory role for the shaykh himself. Most scholarly works on the Sanusiyya describe the order as teaching only union with the Prophet, to the exclusion of union with God, and stress that union with the Prophet was enjoined as the goal for all members of the order, not only an elite.[61] F. de Jong contradicts this point of view and says that the *awrād* of the Sanusiyya make it clear that, true to the ideas of Ibn Idris, "the desired union with the Prophet must be conceived of as a union in which the Prophet is a manifestation of the divine essence, *al-nūr al-muḥammadī*, which is the substance of substances and the basis of all existence. Therefore, it is a union with the Divine itself, through the Divine as manifested in and made accessible through the Prophet."[62]

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Nicola Ziadeh describes the process by which union with the Prophet was accomplished:

> To begin with, it meant austerity and asceticism, which had to be adhered to strictly. The material world had to be renounced, even at the outset. . . . Luxurious living is forbidden. This includes silk garments, jewelry, dancing, singing, smoking, and coffee drinking. But . . . the spiritual aspect of the Sanusi path is [even] more strenuous. First and foremost is the exclusion of all but God from one's thought and the continuous keeping of the vision of the Prophet in one's mind. One's life should be perfected through an imitation of the Prophet in word and deed. Thus, internally and externally one should be occupied with the Prophet, saying and repeating prayers in his name.

This regimen would result in visions of the Prophet both in dreams and while awake.[63] One prayer that was recited by disciples asked God to "unite me with him [the Prophet] as you have united the spirit and the soul, outwardly and inwardly, waking and sleeping, and make him the spirit of my being under all aspects, in this life as in the next."[64]

Muhammad ᶜUthman al-Mirghani, founder of the Mirghaniyya order and another disciple of Ahmad ibn Idris, also encouraged his disciples to seek to attain union with the Prophet. One of the techniques used was to "imagine that you are standing facing him [the Prophet], as though you are before him, face to face, and that he hears you and sees you even though he is far away, for he does hear, through God, and see through Him, and nothing, near or far, is hidden from him."[65] Al-Mirghani clearly advocates the three-step process of *fanāʾ* typical of later Sufism: annihilation in the shaykh, then in the Prophet, and finally in God.[66] But from the outset of their journey on the Sufi Path, al-Mirghani's disciples are to place before their mind's eye the image of the Prophet alongside that of their shaykh.[67]

In the case of the Idrisi tradition, therefore, it appears that despite the social, moral, and political reformism of such orders as the Sanusiyya, union with (or annihilation in) the Prophet is not intended as a substitute for annihilation in God. It also appears that whatever organizational innovations neo-Sufism might have introduced, it did not involve a rejection of medieval Sufism's metaphysical goals or the teachings of Ibn ᶜArabi, but represented strong continuity with the form of *fanāʾ fī ʾl-rasūl* described in the writings of al-Jili.

CONCLUSION

We have established that Sufis have been trying to attain personal contact with the Prophet in some form at least as far back as Ibn ᶜArabi, through techniques of prayer, blessing the Prophet, and visualization. The terms used for this contact vary—vision (*ruʾyā*), annihilation (*fanāʾ*), witness (*mushāhada*), meeting or joining (*jamᶜ* or *ijtimāᶜ*), and union (*ittiḥād*)—and a difference can be detected between, on the one hand, the assurance of the reality of one's vision of the Prophet, and of God in the Prophet, in the writings of Ibn ᶜArabi and al-Jili, and, on the other, the possibility of distortion and a lesser vision of the Prophet's form in the teaching of al-Dabbagh.

The connection of both the Tijaniyya and the Idrisi tradition with Ibn ᶜArabi is significant. The main contention of this paper is that the practice of meditation on

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the Prophet with the goal of achieving annihilation in him predates the "two Ahmads" by several centuries. It even predates the Muhammadan Path spawned by the 16th-century followers of the 15th-century Moroccan Shaykh Muhammad ibn Sulayman al-Jazuli,[68] for explicit instructions regarding its methods and goals can be found in *Qāb al-qawsayn* by al-Jili. The recent work of O'Fahey and other scholars indicates that there is little justification for saying that "neo-Sufism" implies any innovation in mystical doctrine or any rejection of the thought of Ibn ᶜArabi. This article outlining the development of the practice of union with the Prophet as seen through the teachings of Ibn ᶜArabi, al-Jili, and al-Dabbagh indicates that the concept of annihilation in the Prophet is not associated with Islamic reformism or with efforts to affirm the transcendence of God through (somewhat illogically) the near-deification of a man, but is associated with the school of Ibn ᶜArabi and his teachings of the unique cosmic role of Muhammad and the "Muhammadan Reality."

It is clear, therefore, that the practice of annihilation in the Messenger by Sufis in the tradition of Ahmad ibn Idris represents neither an innovation nor a rejection of Ibn ᶜArabi, whose influence on popular Sufism continues to be palpable today, even if it is, to a certain extent, "vulgarized," to quote Alexander Knysh.[69] Among the Sufi orders in contemporary Egypt, the practice of annihilation in the Messenger is not primarily associated with orders with a reputation for reformism, but rather is taught in the main Sufi orders—the Rifaᶜiyya, Shadhiliyya, and Khalwatiyya, for example—though it is considered an esoteric doctrine to be discussed only with those who are sufficiently mature, and annihilation must first occur in the shaykh.[70]

This study adds to the doubts raised by previous scholars about the usefulness of the term "neo-Sufism" and proposes that annihilation in the Messenger is linked with the doctrines of Ibn ᶜArabi concerning the Muhammadan Reality and did not originate with modern Islamic reformism. The practice of meditation on the Prophet may have undergone changes and appears to have gained in importance in recent centuries, but it is not a radical departure from pre-modern Sufi tradition.

NOTES

Author's Note: Consultation of the Bibliothèque Nationale's manuscript of *Al-Kamālāt al-ilāhiyya fiʾl-ṣifāt al-muḥammadiyya* was enabled by a visiting scholarship from the École des Hautes Études en Sciences Sociales and a grant from the Research Board at the University of Illinois.

[1]Abū ʾl-Faḍl Qāḍī ᶜIyāḍ ibn Mūsā al-Yaḥsūbī al-Sabṭī, *Kitāb al-shifāʾ bi taᶜrīf al-muṣṭafā* (The Book of Healing by Acquainting [the Reader] with the Chosen One) (Beirut: Dār al-Kitāb al-ᶜIlmiyya, 1979), 2 volumes in 1.

[2]For example, the Qurʾan commentary by Muqātil (d. 767), a Zaydi Shiᶜi: Paul Nwyia, *Exégèse coranique et langage mystique*, Recherches de l'Institut de Lettres Orientales, vol. 49 (Beirut: Dar el-Machreq, 1970), 95. Among the Sunnis, the doctrine of the Muhammadan light was first expounded by the Sufi Sahl al-Tustarī (d. 896): Gerhard Böwering, *The Mystical Vision of Existence in Classical Islam: The Qurʾanic Hermeneutics of the Sufi Sahl at-Tustari (d. 283/896)* (New York: de Gruyter, 1980).

[3]Muḥammad ibn Sulaymān al-Jazūlī, *Dalāʾil al-khayrāt wa shawāriq al-anwār fī dhikr al-ṣalāt ᶜalā ʾl-nabī al-mukhtār* (Proofs of the Good Things and the Radiance of Lights in the Recollection of Blessing the Chosen Prophet), ms. no. 377 (Marrakesh: Ben Yūsuf Library).

[4]Constance E. Padwick, *Muslim Devotions: A Study of Prayer Manuals in Common Use* (London: Society for Promoting Christian Knowledge, 1961), xviii, 149.

[5]Jonathan G. Katz, *Dreams, Sufism and Sainthood: The Visionary Career of Muhammad al-Zawawi* (Leiden, New York, Cologne: E. J. Brill, 1996), xx.

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[6]There has been a great deal of disagreement as to the date of death of al-Jili, ranging from 1402/3, as indicated on some of the published editions of *Al-Insān al-kāmil* (The Perfect Man), to 1428, the date provided by Carl Brockelmann in his *Geschichte der arabischen Literatur.* I rely on information from Michel Chodkiewicz, who, in a letter dated 23 May 1995, wrote that the India office manuscript of *Ghunyat arbāb al-samāᶜ* (Sufficiency of the Masters of Audition) by al-Jili states (f. 295b) that al-Jili's son wrote at the end of a manuscript of *Al-Insān al-kāmil* that his father died in Jumāda II 811 (November 1408 A.D.). Although Louis Massignon says that he saw al-Jili's tomb in Baghdad (*Receuil des textes inédits concernant l'histoire de la mystique en pays d'Islam* [Paris, 1929], 148, n. 2), Chodkiewicz writes that al-Jili is buried in Zabid next to his shaykh, al-Jabartī, and that a recent letter from Yemen indicates that his tomb is still visited.

[7]Ibn ᶜArabī, *Al-Futūḥāt al-makkiyya* (Beirut: Dār Ṣādir, 1966), 1:134–35, 144–45.

[8]Muḥyī ᵓl-Dīn ibn al-ᶜArabī (Ibn ᶜArabī), *Fuṣūṣ al-ḥikam* (Bezels of Wisdom), ed. Abū ᵓl-Aᶜlā ᶜAffīfī (Beirut: Dār al-Kitāb al-ᶜArabī, 1966), 2 vols., 1:49.

[9]William C. Chittick, *The Sufi Path of Knowledge: Ibn al-ᶜArabi's Metaphysics of Imagination* (Albany: State University of New York Press, 1989), 21.

[10]Ibn ᶜArabī, *Al-Futūḥāt al-makkiyya*, 1:134–35, 150, and frequently throughout the text.

[11]Ibid., 3:251.

[12]Ibid., 4:184.

[13]*Dhikr*, "remembrance" of God, is a Qurᵓanic term (33:41, 29:45, and many other verses) that normally denotes, in the Sufi context, ritualized recitation or recollection of the Names of God, though here Ibn ᶜArabi is encouraging the recitation of blessings on the Prophet as one's personal *dhikr.* Sufi shaykhs must give each disciple a particular *dhikr* suitable for him or her to perform in private devotions.

[14]Ibn ᶜArabī, *Al-Futūḥāt al-makkiyya*, 4:184.

[15]Ibid.

[16]*Qāb qawsayn* was published by Yūsuf al-Nabhānī in his *Jawāhir al-biḥār fī faḍāᵓil al-nabī al-mukhtār* (The Gems of the Seas in the Virtues of the Chosen Prophet) (Cairo: Muṣṭafā al-Bābī al-Ḥalabī and Sons, 1966). It was re-published in *Tabriᵓat al-dhimma fī nuṣḥ al-umma wa tadhikrat ūlī ᵓl-albāb li ᵓl-sayr ilā ᵓl-ṣawāb* (Discharging the Duty to Counsel the Nation and a Reminder for Those with Pure Hearts to Travel the Right Path) by the controversial Sudanese shaykh of the Burhāniyya, Muḥammad ᶜUthmān al-Burhānī (d. 1983) (Khartoum: Burhāniyya Dasūqiyya Shādhiliyya Order, 1974?). The latter book became the object of a vitriolic press campaign in Egypt in 1976 and has been banned in that country, allegedly for teaching heterodox doctrines deemed inconsistent with Sunni Islam, especially ideas concerning the Muhammadan Reality and the cosmic stature of the Prophet and his family. However, there is nothing original in the book at all. It reproduces verbatim texts from Ibn ᶜArabi, al-Jili, Suyuti, and others, which demonstrate the superiority of the Prophet and his family and the veneration due them. It appears that the campaign against the Burhaniyya might have had political or economic motives, although it is also possible that the doctrines disseminated in the book were thought to be appropriate for advanced Sufis, but not for public consumption. On the contents of this book and the criticism of it in the Egyptian press, see Valerie J. Hoffman, *Sufism, Mystics, and Saints in Modern Egypt* (Columbia: University of South Carolina Press, 1995), chap. 10. Al-Nabhani says that he used manuscripts of al-Jili's work from Cairo and Medina, and that he also bought another copy from a bookseller who came from Aleppo. Muhammad ᶜUthman simply reprinted Nabhani's version of the text.

[17]I read a manuscript of this text at the Bibliothèque Nationale in Paris. Other copies exist in Cairo, Damascus, and Rabat, among other places.

[18]This is generally said to be a *ḥadīth qudsī*, but it is not found in books of hadith. See William C. Chittick's notation in *Faith and Practice of Islam: Three Thirteenth Century Sufi Texts* (Albany: State University of New York Press, 1992), 201, line 60.2.

[19]Bibliothèque Nationale, ms. no. 1338_6, f. 169b.

[20]When I delivered an earlier version of this paper at the Muhyiddin Ibn ᶜArabi Society Symposium, Berkeley, November 1994, John Mercer commented, in the symposium's closing remarks, on the irony of "adorning" oneself by "stripping."

[21]Bibliothèque Nationale, ms. no. 1338_6, f. 217a.

[22]*Qāb qawsayn*, in Nabhānī, *Jawāhir al-biḥār*, 4:228.

[23]A Qurᵓanic phrase (2:256, 31:22) of ambiguous reference.

[24]*Qāb qawsayn*, in Nabhānī, *Jawāhir al-biḥār*, 4:218. Although I have translated the quote as if al-Jili were talking to one individual, many of the words are in the plural. Al-Jili moves freely between the sin-

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gular and the plural, and I felt that keeping the translation in the singular better conveyed the meaning and sense of intimacy contained in his writing. The last phrase, "looking at their Lord," which grammatically does not fit with what precedes it, is taken from Qurʾan 75:23: "On that day faces will be radiant, looking at their Lord." The Qurʾanic context refers to the Last Day, and the faces are those of the righteous, but al-Jili uses the same phrase to refer to what is commonly called *mushāhada*, "witnessing" in mystical experience the divine realities.

[25]Ibid., 227.

[26]Ibid., 231.

[27]Ibid., 232.

[28]Ibid., 236.

[29]Ibid., 237–38.

[30]Ibid., 239.

[31]"Young manliness" (in contrast to the pre-Islamic ethic of *muruwwa*, "manliness") or "chivalry," usually a word referring to a code of Sufi ethics. Qushayri applies this word in his *Risāla* to the annihilation of the ego, for the *fatā* ("young man") in the Qurʾan is Abraham, crusher of the idols, and the idol of every human being is his own soul or ego: Abū ʾl-Qāsim ʿAbd al-Karīm al-Qushayrī, *Al-Risāla ʾl-qushayriyya fī ʿilm al-taṣawwuf* (The Treatise of al-Qushayrī on the Science of Sufism) (Cairo: Maktabat Muḥammad ʿAlī Ṣubayḥ, n.d.), 177.

[32]*Qāb qawsayn*, in Nabhānī, *Jawāhir al-biḥār*, 4:239.

[33]"Annihilation in the shaykh" (*fanāʾ fī ʾl-shaykh*) is based on the idea that the shaykh is the most perfect manifestation of the Prophet available to the disciple, and the Prophet is in turn the most perfect manifestation of God. Disciples who visualize their shaykh in meditation and love him deeply may attain to such a deep identification with the shaykh as to achieve "annihilation" of their own egos in him. In so doing, the disciple acquires some of the spiritual realizations of the shaykh, which ultimately leads the disciple into the presence of the Prophet, as he sees the Prophet through his shaykh. It is not certain when this practice developed, although Annemarie Schimmel cites the phrase *fanāʾ fī ʾl-shaykh* from a poem by Farīd al-Dīn ʿAṭṭār (d. 1220). The Naqshbandiyya consider *tawajjuh*, concentration upon the shaykh, as necessary for the successful performance of *dhikr*: Annemarie Schimmel, *Mystical Dimensions of Islam* (Chapel Hill: University of North Carolina Press, 1975), 237.

[34]According to Aditya Behl, who presented a paper titled, "Yoga in Sufi Circles: The Shattaris of Mughal India," at the American Academy of Religion annual meeting, November 1993. The text in question is called *Jām-i jihān nāma* and has not been published.

[35]This is a point made by James Winston Morris in "Ibn ʿArabi and His Interpreters, Part II (Conclusion): Influences and Interpretations," *Journal of the American Oriental Society* 107, 1 (1987): 101–19; see esp. 109, concerning al-Jili's commentary on Ibn ʿArabi's *Risalat al-Anwar*: "What is remarkable about that commentary, in comparison with the works by authors discussed earlier in this section, is its consistent, unmistakable reference to direct experience of the realities in question, not just as a premise of the discussion, but as its very *raison d'être*. Al-Jili, like Ibn ʿArabi and unlike so many of his other commentators, is careful here to raise questions of 'theory' or intellectual explanation as they naturally arise within the context and ultimate aim of spiritual realization—not as they are generated by extraneous apologetic concerns, or by an internal intellectual dialectic taken as an end in itself."

[36]Talk by Arthur F. Buehler at the American Academy of Religion annual meeting, November 1993.

[37]Bernd Radtke is currently involved in translating *Al-Ibrīz* into English and has written two articles on the book: "Zwischen Traditionalismus und Intellektualismus: Geistesgeschichtliche und historiografische Bemerkungen zum Ibriz des Ahmad b. Al-Mubarak al-Lamati," *Built on Solid Rock: Studies in Honour of Professor Ebbe Egede Knudsen on the Occasion of His 65th Birthday, April 11, 1997*, ed. Elie Wardini (Oslo, 1997), 240–42, and "Ibriziana: Themes and Sources of a Seminal Sufi Work," *Sudanic Africa* 7 (1996): 113–58.

[38]According to Michel Chodkiewicz, *Un Océan sans rivage: Ibn Arabie, le livre et la loi* (Paris: Editions du Seuil, 1992), 30–31.

[39]*Wird* (pl. *awrād*) is a prayer or litany that must be given to a Sufi disciple by his master for daily recitation and is thought to be the key to enlightenment. *Dhikr* is part of the individual Sufi's daily *wird*.

[40]Borno was a kingdom in what is today northeastern Nigeria and northern Cameroon, south of Lake Chad.

[41]*Al-Ibrīz* (Beirut: Dār al-fikr, n.d.), 13–16.

[42]Although in earlier Sufi and philosophical works *dhāt* means "essence," and must still mean that with respect to God, who does not have a body, it is clear from the context of the text that in this case

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dhāt means the physical body. Fritz Meier previously noted this use of the word *dhāt* in "Eine Auferstehung Mohammeds bei Suyuti," *Der Islam* 62 (1985): 46, n. 81.

[43]*Al-Ibrīz*, 511.

[44]Ibid., 172–73.

[45]Ibid., 518.

[46]Fazlur Rahman, *Islam*, 2nd ed. (Chicago and London: University of Chicago Press, 1979), 206.

[47]H. A. R. Gibb, *Mohammedanism*, 2nd ed. (London, Oxford, and New York: Oxford University Press, 1970), 117.

[48]J. Spencer Trimingham, *The Sufi Orders in Islam* (Oxford: Clarendon Press, 1971), 106.

[49]John Obert Voll, *Islam: Continuity and Change in the Modern World* (Boulder, Colo.: Westview Press, 1982), 55.

[50]Katz, *Dreams, Sufism and Sainthood*, xx.

[51]R. S. O'Fahey and Bernd Radtke, "Neo-Sufism Reconsidered," *Der Islam* 70, no. 1 (1993): 52–87. This article contains a thorough summary of recent debates about neo-Sufism and addresses all aspects of its definition, not only the metaphysical doctrines considered here. The summary of the major characteristics of neo-Sufism is on p. 57, and is based on Trimingham, *Sufi Orders*, 106–7; B. G. Martin, *Muslim Brotherhoods in 19th-Century Africa* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1976), 71–72, 108; and Voll, *Islam*, 55–59, 65–67, 76–79, 103–4, 134–36.

[52]Jamil M. Abun-Nasr, *The Tijaniyya: A Sufi Order in the Modern World* (London, New York, Toronto: Oxford University Press, 1965), 29–40, 57.

[53]Although this term describes Ibn ᶜArabī's doctrine, it originates not with him, but with his disciple and son-in-law, Ṣadr al-Dīn al-Qūnawī (d. 1274). On the various ways of looking at the meaning of *waḥdat al-wujūd*, usually translated as "oneness of being," see Chittick, *The Sufi Path*, 3, 6–8.

[54]O'Fahey, *Enigmatic Saint*, 102–3, 209.

[55]For a strong argument regarding Ibn ᶜArabī's pervasive influence on Sufi thought, see Chodkiewicz, *Un Océan sans rivage*, 17–37.

[56]O'Fahey and Radtke, "Neo-Sufism Reconsidered," 71–73.

[57]O'Fahey, *Enigmatic Saint*, 130–42.

[58]Aḥmad al-Sharīf al-Sanūsī, *Al-Anwār al-qudsiyya fī muqaddamāt al-ṭarīqa l-sanūsiyya* (Istanbul: Maṭbaᶜat ᶜĀmira, 1920–23), 5.

[59]E. E. Evans-Pritchard, *The Sanusi of Cyrenaica* (Oxford: Clarendon Press, 1949), 4. Given the previously discussed use of the term *dhāt* in the meaning of body, it is not clear whether "body" would not have been preferable to "essence" in Evans-Pritchard's translation.

[60]*Handbook on Cyrenaica*, pt. 10 (Cairo, 1943), 29; cited in Nicola A. Ziadeh, *Sanusiyah: A Study of a Revivalist Movement in Islam* (Leiden: E. J. Brill, 1958), 88.

[61]For example, Aḥmad Sidqī al-Dajjānī says that the Sanusis believed in the possibility of union (*ittiḥād*) with the Prophet and aimed to achieve that. "They do not go beyond that goal to believe in the possibility of union with God, as some of the other Sufi orders have done": Al-Dajjānī, *Al-Ḥaraka ʾl-sanūsiyya* (Beirut: Dār Lubnān, 1967), 247. Nicola Ziadeh reports similarly in *Sanusiyah*, 87.

[62]F. de Jong, *Ṭuruq and Ṭuruq-Linked Institutions in Nineteenth Century Egypt* (Leiden: E. J. Brill, 1978), 151–52, n. 120.

[63]Ziadeh, *Sanusiyah*, 87–88.

[64]*Majmūᶜatu ʾl-wird al-kabīr*, trans. Padwick, *Muslim Devotions*, 151.

[65]*Al-Fayḍ wa ʾl-madad min ḥaḍrat al-rasūl al-sanad*, trans. Padwick, *Muslim Devotions*, 150.

[66]O'Fahey and Radtke, "Neo-Sufism Reconsidered," 70.

[67]O'Fahey, *Enigmatic Saint*, 202.

[68]Vincent Cornell suggests that the Jazuliyya brotherhood, "in their creation of the concept of the 'Muhammadan method' (*al-ṭarīqa ʾl-muḥammadiyya*), their advocacy of the Sharifian ideology of political rule, and their systematic attempts at transforming the nature of social relations in the regions where they lived . . . may have been the first truly 'neo-Sufi' movement in the history of Islam": Vincent Cornell, "Mirrors of Prophethood: The Evolving Image of the Spiritual Master in the Western Maghrib from the Origins of Sufism to the End of the Sixteenth Century" (Ph.D. diss., University of California at Los Angeles, 1989), 30.

[69]Alexander Knysh, "Ibn ᶜArabi in the Yemen: His Admirers and Detractors," *Journal of the Muhyiddin Ibn ᶜArabi Society* 10 (1992): 49. Knysh appears to be quite critical of al-Jili, saying that he advocated

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abandoning ascetic exercises and meditation in favor of obtaining knowledge from the writings of Ibn ᶜArabi. The passage Knysh quotes, however, appears to indicate that the writings of Ibn ᶜArabi were a more reliable guide to knowledge than any insights a novice might be able to obtain on his own. As Knysh puts it, "Al-Shaykh al-Akbar's works may be used as a kind of short-cut, leading the novice directly to a greater conceptual clarity, and, in the long run, to a spiritual and intellectual perfection." What appears to be implied is that the individual disciple cannot hope to arrive through his own efforts at the depth of wisdom Ibn ᶜArabi obtained, and these were already available in Ibn ᶜArabi's writings. It does not appear to me that al-Jili is advocating abdicating spiritual exercises or personal insight. Indeed, that characterization appears to be refuted by the fact that al-Jili's own writings represent modifications of Ibn ᶜArabi's doctrine based on his own mystical experiences, as Najāh Maḥmūd al-Ghunaymī demonstrates in *Al-Manāẓir al-ilāhiyya li ᵓl-Shaykh ᶜAbd al-Karīm al-Jīlī* ("The Divine Visions" by Shaykh ᶜAbd al-Karīm al-Jīlī) (Cairo: Dār al-Manār, 1987). James Morris also writes, "Jīlī proceeds to develop the same broad themes (metaphysics, cosmology, spiritual psychology, etc.) [as his predecessors in the "school" of Ibn ᶜArabī and Qūnawī], but with an originality and independence which is consistently grounded—like Ibn ᶜArabī's—in his own spiritual insight and experience": Morris, "Ibn ᶜArabi and His Interpreters," 108.

[70]Hoffman, *Sufism, Mystics, and Saints*, 64–65, 140–41.

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